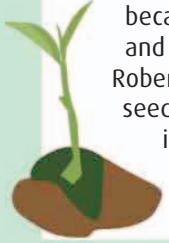


INFILTRATING CHINA

Despite the discovery of indigenous tea plants in India, the EIC preferred the Chinese tea plant (var. *sinensis*). The *sinensis* variety proved to be better stock than the *assamica* variety because it could withstand the cooler weather and higher altitudes of Darjeeling. Botanist Robert Fortune was sent to obtain cuttings, seeds, and knowledge from China's inner provinces. During his trip from 1848–1851, Fortune shipped seeds and seedlings to India.



Chinese gaiwan



OPIUM WARS

While British tea gardens in India were being established the EIC continued to trade with China. The EIC sold opium, grown in India, to the Chinese in exchange for silver that they would then use to purchase tea. By the 1820s, opium addiction in China was widespread, which led the Chinese government to make smoking opium illegal. Since the opium trade went on despite these bans, two Opium Wars were fought between China and Britain, in the years between 1839 and 1860.

1778

Naturalist Joseph Banks recommends to the British government that tea be grown in northeast India

1823

Indigenous tea plants of the *assamica* variety are discovered in Assam, India

1837

America starts to trade directly with China

1839–1860

Opium wars

1784

British Prime Minister William Pitt reduces the tax on tea from 119 percent to 12.5 percent, making it more affordable for the working classes

1835

First cultivated tea plants grown in Assam using cuttings from indigenous var. *assamica* plants

1838

A small harvest of tea from Assam is sent to London for review

TEA FOR THE MASSES

During most of the 18th century in Britain, tea was priced out of reach of the working classes, but when the government reduced the duty on tea in 1784 they effectively ended tea smuggling and made tea affordable for most people.

The working class drank a low grade of tea and incorporated it into their daily meal, serving it with bread, butter, and cheese. Tea was drunk instead of ale, the popular drink of the time, so the health and mental alertness of the population improved.

TEA PLANTING IN INDIA

Long delivery times, high prices, and trade imbalances convinced the EIC that in order to have a steady source of tea they must begin to grow it in India. The first cultivated plants were grown in Assam, India, in 1835, although it would be more than a decade before tea was harvested on a large scale. By the 1870s, privately owned tea gardens expanded throughout Assam and Darjeeling, providing Britain with a cheaper, and more abundant, source of tea than the Chinese had been able to.